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THE BATTLE FOR ISRAEL'S SOUL

> *"If all or any of the French Jews protest against this scheme on account of their own 'assimilation', my answer is simple: The whole thing does not concern them at all. They are Jewish Frenchmen, well and good! This is a private affair for the Jews alone."*
>
> Theodor Herzl

How long will Israel survive? In years past, the answer to this question would have dwelt on its physical survival as a small Jewish state surrounded by hostile Arab neighbors. But the Israel of 2017 faces no existential threats. This assessment comes not from dovish leftists but from hard-nosed, security-minded realists like former defense minister Moshe Ya'alon. It would also have asked about the shortages and scarcity that plagued Israel's economy for decades. Again, these are a thing of the past.

Modern Israel presents a paradox. While the country has never been safer, more prosperous, and more accepted than it is today, these improved material circumstances have coincided with a deterioration not just in its politics, but in the very fabric of its society.

There are three important questions to consider about Israel's future. The first concerns its security situation. This book was never meant to be about "the conflict" or "the peace process", subjects about which there is almost nothing original left to say. It was meant to be strictly about Israeli society: the people inside the 1948 borders, in East Jerusalem and the Golan Heights, and in Area C, the two-thirds of the occupied West Bank that remains under complete Israeli control. But, as the prologue suggests, *haMatzav*—"the situation"—kept finding a way to intrude. Israeli politicians, except those on the far left, have become resigned to a seemingly endless state of conflict and occupation. So has a broad swathe of the public. Whether or not you agree with their logic, this dynamic is troubling. It is slowly poisoning the relationship between the nation and the